not let the chance slip away now that I'm playing regularly again. It somehow overrides her state of mind and she convinces me to stay. It is only a couple more days; the game is tomorrow, and then I will fly home. I say OK.

It's strange how hearing news can suddenly morph the same room, the same people, the same situation, into feeling like a completely alien environment. I have been happy calling wherever the England team is as home – until now. As soon as I put the phone down, the hotel room feels so starkly *not* home. I am so suddenly aware of the compromise of doing what I do, of having to miss moments like this, to feel like I am not able to be supportive or even share a collective sadness that I too must be feeling, but cannot yet. I tell nobody about the miscarriage. I just suck it into my chest, as if I hoover up the cloud above my head and pull it inside and play, while Daniella watches the game from home.

She is proud, she says, after she watches the game. She cannot believe I've done it, that it has helped her just to know how strong people can be. I'm not sure that I deserve any praise – I am just numbed out, running in to bowl – feeling like I have quietly changed inside. White sunblock smeared across my nose, I am fuelled that day with a discontent, bowling to Sanath Jayasuriya – his Sri Lanka World Cup-winning team of 1999 still framed in my mind as a coming-of-age moment, but now bridging a gap between watching cricket in Burnley and bowling at him here in Colombo. He is taking me on, as is his general way of playing, and I roll my hands over the ball, taking the pace off it, a version of an off-cutter which he does not read and, shot already half played, hits the ball tamely to Kevin Pietersen. I run towards Kevin and my team, no smile, no celebrating, high-fiving each of them with a sense of angry duty.

I still have not told anyone in that same huddle what is happening. The only person I speak to about it is the team manager straight after the game, asking him to book me a flight home as soon as he can. We have told everyone about the pregnancy, overexcitedly, and the players just assume I am desperate to get home to see Daniella. I am on the same flight home as Owais Shah, whose wife has just given birth. He is excited to be going home, to meet his child. I listen to his excitement all the way home – trying not to let on that I am upset or give him an inkling of what is going on.